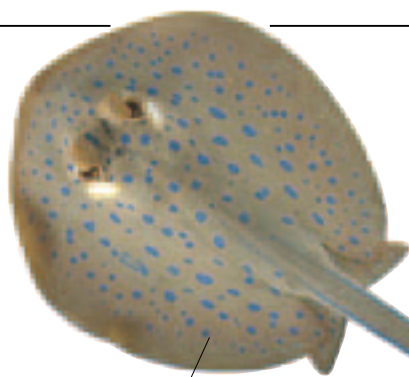




Pectoral fin used for swimming

Two venomous spines on tail can pierce the swimmer's skin and inject its venom

Sting ray's sting is sharp and serrated so it can easily pierce the skin

STING IN THE TAIL

This blue-spotted ray lives in the warm waters of both the Indian and Pacific Oceans as well as the Red Sea, where it is often found lurking on the sandy seabed. If stepped on, shooting pains occur in the foot for over an hour, but, after several hours, the pain gradually wears off.

Painting of sea monsters, c. 1880s



SOMETHING SCARY

Early sailors knew that some creatures living in the sea were dangerous and could kill people. Tales about these sea monsters, though common, often became greatly exaggerated. Monster stories were also invented to account for ships that foundered due to dangerous sea conditions.

VICIOUS JELLYFISH

Jellyfish are well-known for their nasty stings, but the nastiest are those of the box jellyfish, which swim near the coasts of northern Australia and southeast Asia. Its stings produce horrible welts on anyone who comes in contact with their tentacles. A badly stung person can die in four minutes.



When shell is closed, there is still a gap between the shell's two halves

Tentacles always on show

SHAGGY SHELLS

These gaping file shells cannot withdraw their masses of orange tentacles inside the two halves of their shell for protection, so the tentacles produce a sour-tasting, sticky substance to deter predators. If tentacles are nibbled off, they can regrow. Gaping file shells build homes in seaweed, by putting out byssus threads for anchorage. They can also make "nests" among horse mussels and oarweeds. If dislodged from their homes, they can move by expelling water from their shell and using their tentacles like oars.

Shell is up to 1 in (2.5) long